YOUR FIRST FIVE CONVERSATIONS

The scary part isn't the questions. It's the first message.

Plenty of founders know they should talk to customers and still put it off for weeks, because it means asking strangers for time and hearing "no". This sheet makes the first five conversations small and specific: who to ask, what to send, how to spend the 30 minutes, and what to write down afterwards.

ONE WEEK | 6 PAGES | NO NETWORK NEEDED | NO PITCH DECK ALLOWED

NAME THE FEAR BEFORE IT NAMES YOU

WHAT I'M WORRIED WILL HAPPEN

THE WORST REALISTIC OUTCOME

WHAT I LOSE IF I DON'T ASK

a "no" costs you a minute. building the wrong thing costs months.

01 · FIND
Ten names, warmest first, no network required. (p.2)

02 · ASK
Three messages that ask for a story, not a favour. (p.3)

03 · RUN
A 30-minute run sheet, plus what to say when it goes sideways. (p.4)

04 · TRACK
Five calls, one page, and a courage log. (p.5)

FREE TO PRINT AND SHARE. KEEP THIS FOOTER.

Start warm. Cold is the last resort.

From first principles: people say yes when they already care about the problem, or when someone they trust asks them to. Founders who share their outreach stories publicly tend to report the same thing: cold messages mostly go unanswered, while warm intros and people already complaining get replies. So work left to right.

WARMEST	WARM	MILD	COOL	COLD
Already complaining	**One intro away**	**Where they gather**	**Your own past**	**Strangers**
People posting about this problem in forums, reviews, groups. Reply helpfully first. Check each community's rules on self-promotion.	Ask friends, ex-colleagues, classmates: "Who do you know who has dealt with ___ recently?"	Meetups, associations, Slack and Discord groups, courses where your segment already spends time.	People from old jobs, clients, suppliers who fit the segment, even loosely.	Short, specific, no pitch. Expect silence; send more than you need.

MY TEN: PEOPLE WHO HAD THIS PROBLEM RECENTLY

	NAME OR HANDLE	WHERE I FOUND THEM	WARMTH	MESSAGE SENT?
01			W · M · C	
02			W · M · C	
03			W · M · C	
04			W · M · C	
05			W · M · C	
06			W · M · C	
07			W · M · C	
08			W · M · C	
09			W · M · C	
10			W · M · C	

Why five, and why ten names? Five conversations won't prove anything. They tell you whether you're talking to the right people and asking the right questions. Research on interview saturation suggests recurring themes start to repeat after roughly a dozen or so interviews in a fairly similar group, and later when the group is mixed. Ten names gets you five calls if half say yes. Guest, Bunce & Johnson (2006), *Field Methods* 18(1); Hagaman & Wutich (2016), *Field Methods*.

Ask for their story, not your validation.

People like being asked about their own experience. They don't enjoy being asked to judge your idea. Fill in the blanks, keep it short, and send it today.

A · THE WARM-INTRO ASK

TO A FRIEND

Hi _____, quick favour. I'm trying to understand how _____ deal with _____. Do you know anyone who's had to deal with that in the last few months? I'd love 20 minutes to hear how they handle it. I'm not selling anything.

Why it works: you're asking for an introduction, not a sale, and "in the last few months" filters for people with fresh, specific memories.

B · THE REPLY TO SOMEONE WHO COMPLAINED

PUBLIC POST → DM

Hi _____, I saw your post about _____. That sounds painful. I'm researching how people handle this and I'm not selling anything. Would you be up for a 20-minute chat about what happened and what you tried? Happy to share what I learn from others.

Why it works: they've already told the world it's a problem. Lead with their words, and offer something back (a summary of what you learn).

C · THE COLD EMAIL

LAST RESORT

Subject: Quick question about _____

Hi _____, I'm researching how _____ handle _____, and your work at _____ suggests you've seen it up close. Could I ask you about the last time it came up? 20 minutes, your choice of time, and no pitch. If it's not a fit, a one-line "no" is genuinely fine.

Why it works: it's specific about why you chose them, it gives them permission to say no, and it promises no pitch. Then keep that promise.

NEVER IN A FIRST MESSAGE

"Validate"
It tells them you want a yes.

A deck or a link
It turns a chat into a review.

"Would you use…"
Save it. Better still, never ask it.

An hour
Ask for 20 minutes and finish on time.

Thirty minutes, in four parts.

Print this and keep it beside you on the call. Write in the margins. Change it after every conversation.

0–3′ SET-UP	**Lower the stakes.** *“I’m not selling anything. I’m trying to understand how people deal with ___. There are no wrong answers, and specific stories help me most.”*
3–18′ THE LAST TIME	**One real event, in detail.** • *“Tell me about the last time ___ happened.”* • *“What happened just before that? And after?”* • *“What did you try? What did it cost you, in time or money?”* • *“Who else was involved?”*
18–25′ THEIR WORLD	**Zoom out, still about them.** • *“What’s the hardest part about ___?”* • *“Have you looked for a better way? What happened?”* • *“How does this rank against everything else on your plate?”*
25–30′ CLOSE	**Ask for one next step.** • *“Who else should I talk to about this?”* • *“Can I come back to you once I’ve spoken to a few more people?”*

Openers adapted from Y Combinator’s “How to Talk to Users” and Rob Fitzpatrick’s *The Mom Test*.

WHEN IT GOES SIDEWAYS

THEY SAY “Oh, I’d totally use something like that.”	YOU SAY “Thanks! What are you using today? What did it cost you last time?”
THEY START DESIGNING YOUR PRODUCT “You should add a feature that…”	YOU SAY “Interesting. Has that come up for you? When was the last time?”
YOU CATCH YOURSELF PITCHING You’ve been talking for two minutes straight.	YOU DO Stop mid-sentence. *“Sorry, I’m talking too much. Tell me about the last time…”*
THEY GO VAGUE “Usually I just sort of deal with it.”	YOU SAY “Could you walk me through the most recent time, step by step?”

Five calls, one page.

After each call, fill in one row before you do anything else. For the full debrief, use field sheet 04, “The Compliment Trap”.

	WHO (ROLE)	DATE	THE BEST FACT I HEARD (SOMETHING THAT HAPPENED)	NEXT STEP THEY AGREED TO
1				○ NONE
2				○ NONE
3				○ NONE
4				○ NONE
5				○ NONE

COURAGE LOG: WHAT I FEARED VS. WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

	BEFORE THE CALL I WAS WORRIED THAT…	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		

AFTER FIVE CALLS, ASK YOURSELF

Did the same problem come up unprompted more than once? Was I talking to the right kind of person? Which of my questions got stories, and which got opinions?

then book the next five.

INTERVIEW #1 IS THE ONE YOU CAN'T REDO

Rehearse it first.

You get one first conversation with each person. Unassumed gives you as many practice runs as you need before it: a synthetic customer who objects, digresses, goes vague and won't be led, and then a review of **your questions**, not your idea.

SCRIBBLE

A note or napkin photo becomes a first-pass canvas.

REHEARSE

Practise the pushback before a real person sees you sweat.

EVIDENCE

Log what real people said, and watch which beliefs survive.

AI IS REHEARSAL. CUSTOMERS ARE EVIDENCE.

Join the first cohort → unassumed.com

PRIVATE BETA · ONE EMAIL WHEN YOUR SEAT OPENS · NO DRIP SEQUENCE